

Grassland

In parts of the world where it is too dry for trees to grow, yet moist enough to prevent the land from becoming desert, grasses are the dominant plants. Grasses are unusual in that their stems grow from a point near the ground. This means that unlike most other plants, which grow from their tips, grasses are unharmed by grazing. In fact, grazing animals help grasses to maintain their dominance by stunting the growth of competing plants. This creates a vast, open habitat in which there is plenty of plant food—for those that can digest it—but little shelter from the elements.



GRASSLAND SONGBIRDS, such as the skylark, have no trees to perch on, so they broadcast their songs and calls from the air.



SAIGAS form large herds. They look and live like true antelopes (of which there are few in temperate grassland).

Temperate grassland

Before the advent of farming, grassland covered large parts of the temperate world, notably in the northern hemisphere. These vast grasslands—which include the prairies of North America, and the steppes of Europe and central Asia—are nearly all in the center of large landmasses, far away from coasts and their moisture-laden winds. Summers are often warm, but winters can be long and cold, with biting winds.

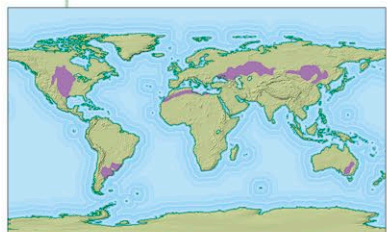
An unusual feature of this kind of habitat is that the majority of the plant matter is hidden away below ground—the exact opposite of the situation elsewhere

on land. This is because grass plants direct much more energy into growing roots than into producing leaves, and their roots form a continuous mat that protects the surface of the ground by holding the soil in place. If grassland is burned, or hit by drought, it can soon recover because the grass can draw on its buried reserves in order to start growing again.

The root mat makes a

useful source of food for insects and other small animals. It is also a perfect medium for burrowers, because it is easy to dig through and, unlike loose soil, rarely caves in.

Above ground, the food supply is closely tied to the seasons. In temperate grassland, most of the year's water usually comes in the form of spring rain or melting snow. This creates a flush of growth during spring and early summer, which is the time that most grazing animals breed. By late summer, the grass is brown and dry, although for a while grass seeds make a valuable fall harvest. Winter is a difficult time for all grassland animals, but particularly for grazers because they often have to survive on low-grade food that is hidden under snow.



THE LARGEST AREAS of temperate grassland are found in North America, South America, eastern Europe, and central and eastern Asia.



THE AMERICAN BISON, now relatively rare, is a large, heavy grazer that once had a profound effect on the ecology of the prairies.



GRASSLAND REPTILES, such as this sand lizard, spend the winter underground and are active in summer.



SOME BIRDS, such as this burrowing owl, lay their eggs in underground burrows because there are no trees to provide nest holes.

GROUND

